
WHAT

Transdisciplinarity: Embracing Collaboration, Tackling Challenges, and Cultivating Equality

Transdisciplinary education has various definitions, but they all agree on one thing: the nature of collaboration. Academic, educational, and non-educational partners join forces in learning, working, and researching.

Participants are united by the central problem or challenge. Transdisciplinarity is focused on engaging with complex societal or sustainability issues that lack clear solutions and methods.

A third characteristic of transdisciplinarity is the form of involvement. In transdisciplinary teams, all partners work together on an equal footing. Relationships can't be defined too rigidly because everyone must learn together to develop new knowledge and innovative ideas and take on various roles during the process. Hence, it is said that "there are no transdisciplinary experts, only transdisciplinary practitioners."

These characteristics pose challenges, especially from a researcher's perspective, who typically works as an expert in a specific field. And: how do educational and research logics relate to each other? TRAIL provides diverse insights and guidelines to help you tackle these challenges.

Inter- or Transdisciplinary: Common Confusions

Literature and experts emphasize that the concept of transdisciplinarity is not always clearly defined (Klein, 2017). The distinction between trans- and interdisciplinary collaboration is often unclear. Both approaches aim for the integration of various types of knowledge. Transdisciplinarity distinguishes itself by involving non-academic stakeholders as equal participants in the collaboration. Therefore, transdisciplinarity encompasses a greater diversity of perspectives and types of knowledge. As complexity increases, so do the challenges and opportunities for learning and new knowledge development.